

STRUCTURE

STRUCTURE 1

SKILL 1: SUBJECT AND A VERB

You know that a sentence in English should have a subject and a verb. The most common types of problems that you will encounter in structure questions on the TOEFL test have to do with subjects and verbs: perhaps the sentence is missing either the subject or the verb or both, or perhaps the sentence has an extra subject or verb.

Example 1

..... was backed up for miles on the freeway

- a. Yesterday
- b. In the morning
- c. Traffic
- d. Cars

In this example you should notice immediately that there is a verb *was*, but there is no *subject*. Answer (c) is the best answer because it contains the singular subject *traffic* that agrees with the singular verb *was*. Answer (a), *yesterday*, and answer (b), *in the morning*, are not subjects, so they are not correct. Although answer (d), *cars*, could be a subject, it is not correct because *cars* is plural and it does not agree with the singular verb *was*.

Example 2

Engineers for work on the new space program.

- a. Necessary
- b. Are needed
- c. Hopefully
- d. Next month

In this example you should notice immediately that the sentence has a subject *engineers* and that there is no verb. Because answer (b), *are needed*, is a verb, it is the best answer. Answers (a), (c), and (d) are not verbs, so they are not correct.

The following outlines what you should remember about subjects and verbs:

A sentence in English must have at least one subject and one verb.

VOCABULARY TIPS

Vocabulary is all about words, the words in a language or a special set of words you are trying to learn. *Vocabulary* is so important; we even created a web site to help expand yours.

Nouns give you a concrete way to talk about the people, places, and things around you. However, too many English learners focus on memorizing long lists of nouns in the beginning. It's easy to get carried away, learning the names of all the animals at the zoo, all the tools in your toolbox, or all the types of clothing in your closet. While you may eventually learn all those nouns, mastering a shorter, more targeted list is a better use of your time.

Verbs are words that show an action (sing), occurrence (develop), or state of being (exist).

Almost every sentence requires a verb.

Noun	Verb
area	accept
book	add
business	admire
case	admit
child	back
company	bake
country	balance
day	ban
eye	bang
fact	calculate
family	call
government	camp
group	dam
hand	damage
home	dance
job	dare
life	earn
lot	educate
man	face
money	fade
month	gather
mother	gaze
Mr	hammer
night	hand
number	identify
part	ignore
people	jail
place	jam
point	kick
problem	kill
program	label
question	land
right	marry
room	match
school	nail
state	name
story	obey
student	object
study	pack
system	paddle
thing	question
time	race
water	radiate
way	sack
week	sail
woman	talk
word	tame

work	undress
world	unfasten
year	vanish

EXERCISE 1.1

Underline the subjects once and the verbs twice in each of the following sentences. Then indicate if the sentences are correct (C) or incorrect (I).

1. Last week went fishing for trout at the nearby mountain lake.
2. A schedule of the day's events can be obtained at the front desk.
3. A job on the day shift or the night shift at the plant available.
4. The new computer program has provides a variety of helpful applications.
5. The box can be opened only with a special screwdriver.
6. The assigned text for history class it contains more than twenty chapters.
7. The papers in the wastebasket should be emptied into the trash can outside.
8. Departure before dawn on a boat in the middle of the harbor.
9. Yesterday found an interesting article on pollution.
10. The new machine is processes 50 percent more than the previous machine.

EXERCISE 1.2

1. The aims of the course me willing to begin.
 - (a) makes
 - (b) make
 - (c) were made
 - (d) making
2. The weight of the mangoes
 - (a) vary
 - (b) might have varied
 - (c) varies
 - (d) were varied
3. The children of the man who works with me broken the window this morning.
 - (a) were
 - (b) has
 - (c) had
 - (d) have
4. Few students who playing football missed the class.
 - (a) would be
 - (b) had
 - (c) were
 - (d) could be
5. The police..... to be careful since the criminal was dangerous.
 - (a) were told
 - (b) was saying
 - (c) was told
 - (d) were telling

6. Neither the woman nor her daughter convinced of the idea.
(a) were
(b) have
(c) was
(d) has
7. Do you know the person next to window?
(a) stands
(b) standing
(c) stood
(d) is standing
8. He and I good friends but now we anymore.
(a) were/won't talk
(b) were/aren't talking
(c) are/weren't talking
(d) have been/don't talk
9. The news he reported us all, we are all in a odd mood.
(a) was astonishing
(b) have astonished
(c) has astonished
(d) astonished
10. Each candidate fill in these forms and sign them.
(a) has to
(b) were to
(c) are to
(d) have to